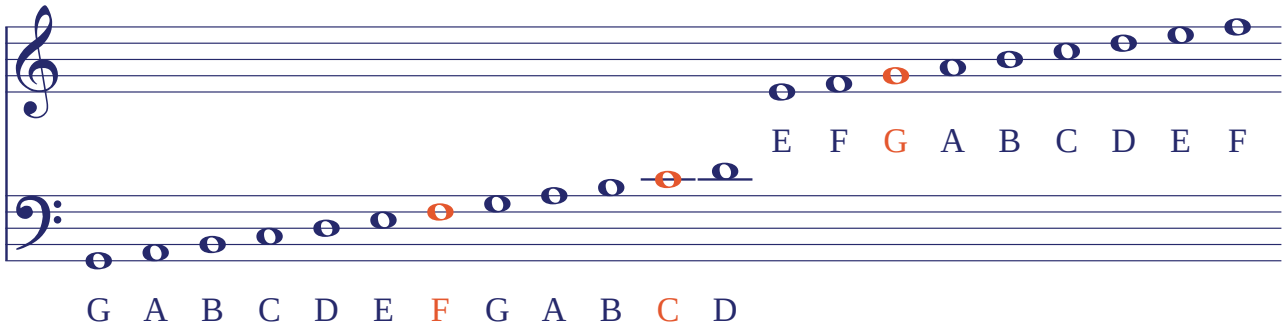
PART I · PITCH · 4

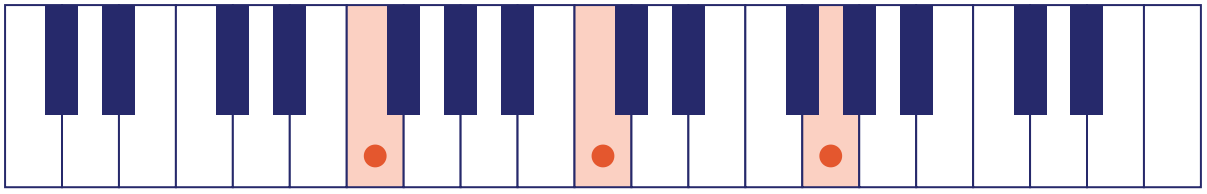
Reading the notes

Every line and space has one letter. You do not have to learn them all at once: start from a note you always know, then **step** or **skip** to the one you want.

THE SECRET

Start from a note you know (bass F, Middle C, treble G), then step or skip.





Middle C in the middle; treble G and bass F, the clef notes, either side. Every line and space is the next letter.

THE RULE

Step: to the very next line or space (one letter on). Skip: line to the next line, or space to the next space (two letters on).

Line note or space note?

A **line note** has the line running through its middle. A **space note** sits between two lines and touches both. Count both from the bottom: line 1 is the bottom line, space 1 the bottom space.

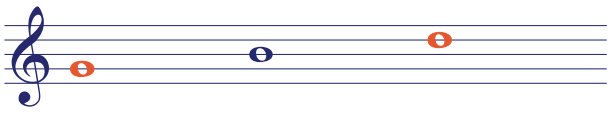
Words to remember the lines and spaces

STAFF	LINES (BOTTOM TO TOP)	SPACES (BOTTOM TO TOP)
Treble	**E G B D F**: *Every Good Boy Deserves Fun*	**F A C E**: they spell *FACE*
Bass	**G B D F A**: *Great Big Dragons Fly Away*	**A C E G**: *All Cows Eat Grass*

PART I · PITCH · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Read a note you are not sure of

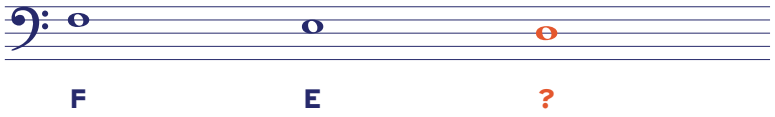


1. **Treble lines** from the bottom: *Every Good Boy Deserves Fun*.
2. **The red note is on line 4:** the fourth word. Which word, which letter?
3. **Check it** from the clef note: G on line 2, skip to B, skip to ...

Line 4 is *Deserves*: **D**. And from the clef: G, B, D, two skips up.

EXAMPLE 2

Read a bass note from the clef



1. **Bass lines** from the bottom: *Great Big Dragons Fly Away*.
2. **The red note is on line 3:** the third word. Which letter?
3. **Check it** from the clef note: the dots hug F on line 4; step down to E, then ...

Line 3 is *Dragons*: **D**. And from the clef: F, E, D, two steps down.

EXAMPLE 3

One line, two notes



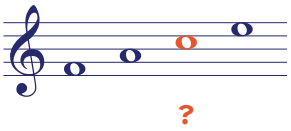
1. **Look at the red notes:** both sit on the bottom line.
2. **Now look at the clefs:** treble on the left, bass on the right.
3. **Use each clef's sentence:** the first word of the treble lines, *Every...*; the first word of the bass lines, *Great...*.

Treble bottom line: **E** (*Every*). Bass bottom line: **G** (*Great*). Same line, different note: always read the **clef** first.

PART I · PITCH · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 4

Find Treble C on the staff

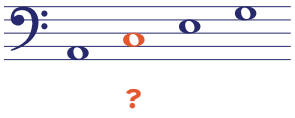


1. **These notes sit in the spaces.** The bottom space is F.
2. **Step up through the spaces:** F, A … they spell a word.
3. **The red note is space 3.** Which letter is it?

F A **C** E: space 3 is **C**, Treble C, the same C you found on the keyboard, one octave above Middle C.

EXAMPLE 5

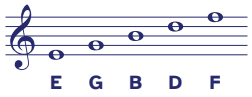
Find Bass C on the staff



1. **These notes sit in the bass spaces.** The bottom space is A: *All.*
2. **Say the next word:** *All Cows …*
3. **The red note is space 2.** Which letter?

A **C** E G: space 2 of the bass staff is **C**, Bass C, one octave below Middle C.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Say the treble lines up and down.

"E G B D F", then "F D B G E", out loud, as fast as you can without a slip. Then the spaces: "F A C E".

GAME

Name it from the clef note

1	2	3	4
treble line 3	treble space 1	bass line 3	bass space 3

Start from the clef note (treble G on line 2, bass F on line 4), then step or skip.

Answer: 1 B (skip up from G) · 2 F (step down from G) · 3 D (two steps down from F) · 4 E (step down from F).

PART I · PITCH · 4 · CONTINUED

HOW TO

Read a new note in three moves

1. **Look at the clef**: treble or bass? That decides every letter.
2. **Find the nearest note you know**: treble G, bass F or Middle C, or use the sentence for lines or spaces.
3. **Step or skip** to the new note, say its name, then play it.
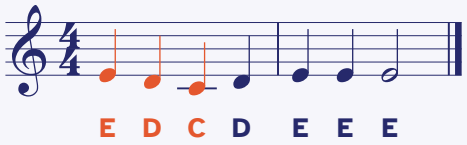
EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Read the shape, not just the notes

Good readers see the jumps before the letters. Notes that touch, line then space, are a **step**: the next letter. Notes with one line between them, line to line or space to space, are a **skip**: one letter missed out. Name the first note, then let the shape name the rest: up a step, up a skip, down a step.

YOU KNOW THIS

Mary Had a Little Lamb



E D C: **line, space, Middle C's own little line**, one step down each time. Read the shape and the tune walks down with it.

Try it. Read the notes aloud before you play them.

THINK OF IT The clef notes are lamp posts on a dark road: walk from the nearest one and you are never lost.

TRAP

- × Naming bass notes with treble names: in the bass, the bottom line is G, not E.
- × Mixing up step and skip: a step changes line to space; a skip stays on lines (or on spaces).
- × Mistaking a space note for a line note: a line runs through a line note; a space note sits between two lines.
- × Counting lines from the top: line 1 is always the bottom line.

SEE ALSO

The staff and the keyboard p. 29 · Ledger lines p. 36

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Pitch 4 · Online: Line and Space Names · Steps & Skips